harmony. Though ignored or disparaged for its supposedly ossified society, Japan continues to do extraordinarily well on international measures of education, health, crime, and the like.

The last three pieces return to the great power struggle for mastery in the Indo-Pacific. Though shelves of books have been written on the recent Sino-American competition, from treatises claiming that China will effortlessly supplant the United States to those darkly predicting war, the much older and arguably more important battle between Japan and China has been all but overlooked, which is the subject of "China versus Japan." For Asian nations, the great historical question is not whether they will choose the outsider America over China, but rather which Asian model to follow, that of Tokyo or Beijing. It was but a few years ago that Japan seemed dominant; now it is China. This competition comprises everything from visions of civil society to economic development models and will continue long after the United States is no longer a major player in the region.

Yet America is not leaving Asia anytime soon, and the following essay takes a long historical look at US strategy in the Indo-Pacific from the beginning of the republic to today. The goal for America remains the same as it has been since 1945—namely, to maintain a balance of power in the Indo-Pacific region while supporting liberal nations that are attempting to create ever more accepted norms and durable links. Such a strategy should not be waylaid by an unwise attempt to contain China, but rather should focus on American strengths and Washington's deep relationships to create meaningful communities of interest on everything from trade to maritime security. Such will do more to blunt China's rise than a frantic attempt to counter every move Beijing makes, and this approach is more sustainable for the long run.

It is the once unimaginable specter of military conflict between China and the United States that drives much of the contemporary commentary on the future of the Indo-Pacific. The final chapter in this volume takes a speculative look from a future historian's perspective at a fictional war between Beijing and Washington, focusing on what precipitated the armed clash and how the conflict unfolded. An era of